



O'Reilly, Coffey & Sheehan Heritage

From County Kilkenny and County Kerry, Ireland, to
Chicago's South Side.

Compiled August 2026

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O'Reilly

From Thomastown to Chicago

The Generations

Generation o

James O'Reilly

Born: c. 1780, Thomastown, Kilkenny, Ireland (Powerswood area)

Spouse: Ellen Walsh

- Born c.1780 in the Thomastown/Powerswood area of County Kilkenny
- Father of Edward (or Edmond) O'Reilly (b.1839)
- Note on Irish naming: the Mac and O prefixes were dropped and added at will — in early records he may appear as 'Reilly' without the O

Ellen Walsh

Born: September 19, 1830, Inistioge, County Kilkenny, Ireland

Died: Thomastown, Kilkenny, Ireland

Spouse: James O'Reilly

- Born in Inistioge — the village on the River Nore near Thomastown, Co. Kilkenny
- Mother of Edward (or Edmond) O'Reilly (b.1839)

Patrick Hanrahan

Born: April 4, 1831, Ballingarry, Callan, Kilkenny, Ireland

Died: December 1902, Callan, Thomastown, Co. Kilkenny, Ireland

Spouse: Ellen Cassin

- Parents: Thomas Hanrahan (b.1810) and Honora Shunny (b.1810)
- Baptism (LDS): 4 Apr 1831, Windgap, Kilkenny
- Married Ellen Cassin on February 23, 1840 at Inistioge, Co. Kilkenny
- Children: Johanna (b.1858), Michael (c.1848), Patrick (b.1855)
- Father of Johanna Hanrahan, who married Edward (Edmond) O'Reilly
- Died December 1902 in Callan, Kilkenny, age 71

Ellen Cassin

Born: April 29, 1836, Inistioge Thomastown, Co. Kilkenny, Ireland

Died: March 1896, Thomastown, Co. Kilkenny, Ireland

Spouse: Patrick Hanrahan

- Baptized 29 Apr 1836 at St. John's, Kilkenny
- Married Patrick Hanrahan on February 23, 1840 at Inistioge
- Mother of Johanna Hanrahan (b.1858)
- Died March 1896 in Thomastown, Co. Kilkenny, age ~59

William Joseph Sheehy

Born: December 1824, Newcastle West, Limerick, Ireland

Died: September 29, 1868

Spouse: Catherine Barrett

- Parents: Richard Sheehy and Hanora Hough — both from Newcastle West, Limerick
- Married Catherine Barrett on November 16, 1856 at the Immaculate Conception Church, Newcastle West, Co. Limerick
- Children: John Sheehy (c.1857), Richard Joseph Sheehy (b.1860), Mary Sheehy
- Died young at age ~33 on September 29, 1868
- Father of Richard Joseph Sheehy (2× great-grandfather, Generation 2)

Catherine Barrett

Born: 1830, Newcastle West, Limerick, Ireland

Spouse: William Joseph Sheehy

- Married William Joseph Sheehy on November 16, 1856 at the Immaculate Conception Church, Newcastle West
- Husband William died September 29, 1868 at age 33
- Mother of Richard Joseph Sheehy (b.1860), who emigrated to Chicago

Patrick Woulfe

From: Cratloe West near Abbeyfeale, Limerick, Ireland

Spouse: Bridget Roche

- Lived in the Cratloe West area of Abbeyfeale, County Limerick
- Father of Anna Woulfe (b.1875) — 2× great-grandmother, Generation 2
- Brought family to America when Anna was 12 (1887)

Bridget Roche

Born: 1850, Cratloe West near Abbeyfeale, Limerick, Ireland

Spouse: Patrick Woulfe

- Mother of Anna Woulfe (b.1875) — 2× great-grandmother, Generation 2
- Came to America with family when Anna was 12 (1887)

Generation 1

Edward (Edmond) O'Reilly

Born: October 13, 1839, Thomastown, Kilkenny, Ireland

Died: February 28, 1892, Thomastown, Kilkenny, Ireland

Spouse: Johanna Hanrahan

Burial: Jerpoint Abbey Graveyard, Thomastown, Kilkenny

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- Died at age 52 — his son Patrick was only 9 years old
 - Buried at Jerpoint Abbey — a 12th-century Cistercian monastery, a significant and historic burial site
 - Married Johanna Hanrahan in 1879 at either the Church of the Assumption in Thomastown or St. Columba's Church in Inistioge
 - History: Edward only had to cross the Arrigle River at the bottom of the O'Reilly farm to be near the Hanrahan home. The Arrigle separates Powerswood from Inistioge.
 - 1911 Census: Residence at Powerswood, Pleberstown, Kilkenny (family still there after his death)
 - 10 children: Bridget (b.1877, d.1965, Coolroemore, Co. Kilkenny, age 87), James (b.1879, d.1955, Powerswood, age 75), Ellen (b.1881, d.1974, New Jersey, age 92), Patrick Joseph (b.1883, emigrated to Chicago 1906), Edward Jr. (b.1885, d.1959, Thomastown, age 74), Johanna (b.1889), Josephine (b.1889), Katie (b.1891), Michael Joseph (b.1893, d.1974, Chicago, age 81), Catherine (buried St. Mary Cemetery, Thomastown)

Johanna Hanrahan

Born: October 13, 1858, Kilkenny, Ireland

Died: March 6, 1949, Thomastown, Kilkenny, Ireland

Spouse: Edward (Edmond) O'Reilly

Burial: St. Mary Cemetery, Thomastown (new cemetery, road to Dublin)

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- Nickname: Judy — all certificates list her as Judy
 - Christened October 13, 1858 at Inistioge, Kilkenny — baptized by Rev. P. Doyle
 - Birth certificate: parents Pat Hanrahan, Powerswood + Ellen Cassin; sponsors Thomas Rafter and Cathirine Rafter
 - Lived to age ~90 — survived her husband by 57 years
 - Remained in Thomastown her entire life
 - Her brother John Hanrahan and sister Bridget Hanrahan were baptism sponsors for Patrick
 - Known relatives: Patrick Hanrahan (first cousin, d.Nov 24 1944); Patrick Hanrahan (1902, nephew, d.Jun 27 1970 age 68); Anne (Hanrahan) Mullins (1864, first cousin, d.Nov 4 1955 age 91); Thomas Mullins (1896, cousin, d.Sep 11 1982 age 86)
 - 1911 Census documents: 4 records surviving at Powerswood, Pleberstown, Kilkenny

Richard Joseph Sheehy

Born: April 17, 1860, Newcastle West, Limerick, Ireland

Died: September 15, 1931, Chicago, Cook County, Illinois

Spouse: Anna Woulfe

Burial: Holy Sepulchre Cemetery, Worth, IL — Lot #39, Section 10

- Parents: William Joseph Sheehy (b.Dec 1824) and Catherine Barrett (b.1830), Newcastle West, Limerick
- Married Anna Woulfe on September 25, 1894 in Chicago
- Arrived in US ~1882-1890 (census sources vary)
- 3 children: Catherine Loretta (b.1894), Marie (b.1898), Anna V. (b.1902)
- Father of Catherine Loretta Sheehy, who married Patrick Joseph O'Reilly
- Died September 15, 1931 in Chicago, age 71

Anna Woulfe

Born: May 18, 1875, Cratloe West, Abbeyfeale, Limerick, Ireland

Died: September 17, 1967, Chicago, Cook County, Illinois

Spouse: Richard Joseph Sheehy

Burial: Holy Sepulcher Cemetery, Worth, IL (alongside husband Richard)

- Nickname: Hanna. Known to great-grandchildren as 'Grandma Shug'
- Parents: Patrick Woulfe and Bridget Roche — both from Cratloe West near Abbeyfeale, Limerick
- Came to the US with her parents at age 12 (1887)
- Siblings: John, Katie, Bridget, Nelly
- Married Richard Joseph Sheehy on September 25, 1894 in Chicago
- Died of ASHD (arteriosclerotic heart disease) at age 92
- Residence at death: 8006 Paulina, Southside Chicago
- Mother of Catherine Loretta Sheehy, who married Patrick Joseph O'Reilly

Generation 2

Patrick Joseph O'Reilly

Born: March 6, 1883, Thomastown, Kilkenny, Ireland

Died: October 25, 1972, Chicago, Cook County, Illinois

Spouse: Catherine Loretta Sheehy

Occupation: City Railway Conductor → Chicago Transit Authority Conductor (1920–1950+). Drove South Side streetcars for 30+ years. Still conducting at age 67 in 1950 when the CTA had replaced the old City Surface Lines.

Immigrated: 1906 (age 23)

Burial: St. Mary's Cemetery, Evergreen Park, IL (buried October 25, 1972)

Physical: Medium build, black hair, grey eyes (WWI Draft Card 1917-18, Cook County Draft Board 20)

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- Christened March 8, 1883 at the Church of the Assumption, Thomastown, by Rev. John Walsh
 - Baptism sponsors: John Hanrahan and Bridget Hanrahan (his mother's siblings)
 - Father died when Patrick was 9 — grew up fatherless in Thomastown
 - Emigrated to the US in 1906 on the SS Celtic, departing Queenstown (Cobh), Ireland
 - Ellis Island arrival: September 2, 1906 — age 22, single, \$5.00 in his pocket
 - Initial destination: Newark, New Jersey — going to his AUNT Annia Hoggins (unknown branch of family)
 - At some point between 1906 and 1918, moved to Chicago where he married Catherine
 - Married Catherine Loretta Sheehy on August 28, 1918 in Chicago
 - WWI Draft Card (1917-1918): registered at 727 E 50th St, Chicago, Draft Board 13. Medium build, medium height, black hair, blue eyes. Listed wife Catherine O'Reilly as relative. Registered in the September 12, 1918 'Old Man's Registration' at age 35 — the war ended just 2 months later. Likely never served.
 - Lived to age 89 — his grandson Terrence (Generation 4) would have been ~16 when Patrick died
 - Ancestry sources: Irish Civil Registration (Mar 1883), Church baptism, 1920 Census, 1940 Census, SSDI (SSN 319-07-3900), Cook County Marriage Index, WWI Draft Card
 - 5 children: Loretta Josephine (1919-2000), Edward 'Bud' (1921-2002), Richard Joseph (1923-1980), James Patrick 'Uncle Jay' (1924-2012), Jerome (b.1932, possibly still living)

Catherine Loretta Sheehy

Born: September 30, 1894, Chicago, Cook County, Illinois

Died: October 9, 1990, Arlington Heights, Cook County, Illinois

Spouse: Patrick Joseph O'Reilly

Burial: St. Mary's Cemetery, Evergreen Park, IL

- Born in Chicago — an Irish-American, not an immigrant
- Father: Richard Joseph Sheehy (1860-1931); Mother: Anna Woulfe (1875-1967)
- Home address: 2821 W. 85th Place, Chicago, IL
- Lived to age 96 — her grandson Terrence (Generation 4) would have known her well
- Married Patrick on August 28, 1918 in Chicago
- Sisters: Marie Sheehy (b.1898, d.1993, age 94) and Anna V. Sheehy (b.1902, d.1975, Chicago, age 73)
- Ancestry sources: Cook County Marriage Index, 1920/1940 Census, SSDI (722-03-2283), 1910 Census

Their 5 children: Loretta Josephine (1919-2000), Edward Joseph 'Bud' (1921-2002), Richard Joseph (1923-1980, died at 56), James Patrick (1924-2012, bachelor missionary in Deming, NM), Jerome (b. 1932, possibly still living)

Generation 3

Edward Joseph "Bud" O'Reilly

Born: January 24, 1921, Chicago, Illinois

Died: April 7, 2002

Spouse: Eileen M. Coffey

Occupation: U.S. Army Veteran (WWII)

Burial: Holy Sepulchre Catholic Cemetery, Alsip, Cook County, Illinois — CONFIRMED (Find A Grave memorial #50749310). Same cemetery as John J. Coffey and Julia Coffey. The O'Reilly and Coffey families are buried together at Holy Sepulchre.

Physical: 5'11", 165 lbs, black hair, blue eyes, ruddy complexion

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- Born Edward Francis — adopted confirmation name Joseph, thereafter went by Edward Joseph O'Reilly (EJ O'Reilly)
 - Second of 5 children — older sister Loretta was born 1919
 - Leo High School, class of 1938 (yearbook photo confirmed)
 - WWII Veteran — U.S. Army. WWII Draft Card (Feb 16, 1942, Chicago): listed as STUDENT, 5'11", 165 lbs, black hair, blue eyes, ruddy complexion. Next of kin: mother Catherine O'Reilly. Enlisted January 21, 1942 per family records. Discharged January 5, 1946. Nearly 4 years of service. Service Number 16070923.
 - Family says Patton's 3rd Army, Battle of the Bulge (unverified — Army personnel files largely destroyed in 1973 NPRC fire)
 - Brought home a captured German pistol
 - Post-war career details pending family verification
 - Children (per O'Reilly family archive): MarySue, JoAnn, Tom, Terry, Patrick, Hugh. Terrence Patrick is Generation 4.
 - Died April 7, 2002 in Oak Lawn, Illinois, age 81
 - Funeral at St. Catherine of Alexandria Church, Oak Lawn
 - Inherited his father Patrick's black hair and blue eyes
 - Document on record: Edward F. O'Reilly's Certificate of Birth

Eileen Marie Coffey

Born: May 18, 1923, Chicago, Illinois

Died: June 20, 2013

Spouse: Edward Joseph "Bud" O'Reilly

Burial: Holy Sepulchre Cemetery, Alsip, IL — Section 19, Block 19, Lot 22, Grave 1

- Had a twin brother Daniel Coffey — both born May 18, 1923, Chicago
- Parents were Irish immigrants from County Kerry
- Grew up at 7748 S. Langley Ave — ONE BLOCK from Edward's address on St. Lawrence Ave
- Told her grandchildren a shipwreck story 2-3 weeks before she died
- Siblings: John Patrick (b.1915), Mary Ellen (b.c.1918), Jeremiah 'Jerry' (b.c.1920), Paul T. (b.c.1921), Daniel (b.1923, her twin — CONFIRMED by 1940 Census: both listed age 16), Loretta (b.c.1924)
- 1930 Census: Eileen listed as 'Jean M. Coffey, age 6' — name mangled by census taker. Twin Daniel listed as 'Donald J. Coffey, age 6'
- 1940 Census: Eileen listed as 'Eillen Coffey, age 16' — Daniel listed as 'Daniel Coffey, age 16'. Twin status CONFIRMED.
- 1940 Census confirms presence in Chicago household at age ~17

Stories & Historical Notes

One Block Apart

Edward O'Reilly's 1942 draft card lists his address as 7341 S. St. Lawrence Avenue. Eileen Coffey grew up at 7748 S. Langley Avenue. These streets are one block apart on Chicago's South Side. The O'Reilly boy and the Coffey girl from Kerry stock — they were neighbors before they were sweethearts.

Two Irish families, one block apart on Chicago's South Side. Some things are not coincidence.

Buried at the Abbey

Edward O'Reilly — Patrick's father and the family's 2× great-grandfather (Generation 1) — is buried at Jerpoint Abbey in Thomastown, Kilkenny. Founded in 1180 by Cistercian monks, the abbey is one of Ireland's finest medieval ruins. Its carved cloister arcade features knights and saints and dragons. Edward died at 52 in 1892, leaving 9-year-old Patrick fatherless. Fourteen years later, Patrick would leave Thomastown for America.

A medieval abbey in Kilkenny. That's where the O'Reilly story begins — and where it rests.

Black Hair, Blue Eyes

Patrick Joseph O'Reilly's 1918 WWI draft card describes him simply: medium build, medium height, black hair, blue eyes. His son Edward 'Bud' inherited the same features — the 1942 WWII draft card records black hair, blue eyes, ruddy complexion. The next generation carries the same coloring. Three generations of O'Reilly men, the same black hair and blue eyes, passed down from a stone town in Kilkenny to Chicago's South Side.

Patrick registered on September 12, 1918 — the 'Old Man's Registration' for men 18 to 45 who hadn't previously registered. He was 35, married to Catherine, with a baby on the way (Loretta would arrive in 1920). The war ended just two months later. Patrick almost certainly never served. But he signed up.

Three generations of O'Reilly men. The same black hair and blue eyes from Kilkenny.

Two Immigrants, One Draft

In 1917, the United States entered World War I. Every man between 18 and 45 was required to register for the draft. Two of the family's great-grandfathers — strangers to each other, from opposite corners of Europe — both walked into registration offices in Illinois and signed their names.

Patrick Joseph O'Reilly, age 35, registered at Draft Board 13 in Chicago. Born in Thomastown, Kilkenny, Ireland. Medium build, black hair, blue eyes. Wife: Catherine O'Reilly. Address: 727 East 50th Street.

Andrew Olaus Linnerud, age 32, registered in Boone County, 80 miles northwest of Chicago. Born in Vinger, Hedmark, Norway. Medium build, dark hair, blue eyes. Wife: Annie Linnerud. Living on a farm.

Neither man likely served. Patrick was 35 with a baby on the way. Andrew was 32 with a young family in rural Illinois. The war ended two months after Patrick's registration. But both signed up. Two immigrants — one Irish, one Norwegian — who had left everything behind for America, and were willing to fight for it.

A generation later, their sons would answer the call for real. Patrick's son Edward 'Bud' enlisted in the Army 45 days after Pearl Harbor. Andrew's son Lyle enlisted in the Coast Guard a year later. Both served the entire war. The fathers registered. The sons went.

Two immigrants who had left everything behind for America, and were willing to fight for it.

The Five Children of Patrick & Catherine

Patrick and Catherine raised five children in Chicago: Loretta Josephine (1919), Edward 'Bud' (1921), Richard Joseph (1923), James Patrick (1924), and Jerome (1932). Richard died at just 56. James Patrick — 'Uncle Jay' — never married, becoming a lifelong bookworm and eventually a missionary in Deming, New Mexico. Jerome, the baby, may still be living at age 94. A photo from the early 1950s shows the four older children together: Richard, James, Edward, and Loretta.

Five Dollars and an Aunt in Newark

On September 2, 1906, a 22-year-old man named Patrick Oreilly walked through Ellis Island and into America.

He had sailed from Queenstown — the main Irish emigrant port, now called Cobh — on the SS Celtic. In his pocket: five dollars. His marital status: single. His declared destination: not Chicago, but Newark, New Jersey. His contact: an aunt named Annia Hoggins.

Annia Hoggins. The name appears on no other family record. She was not an O'Reilly — the name Hoggins suggests she may have been a relation through the Hanrahan side, Patrick's mother's family, already established in America. She was waiting for him in New Jersey.

We don't know how long he stayed in Newark, or what he did there. What we know is that by 1918, Patrick Joseph O'Reilly was in Chicago — and on August 28 of that year, he married Catherine Loretta Sheehy at a Chicago church. Somewhere in the twelve years between Newark and Chicago, he had found his way to the city where he would spend the rest of his life.

He arrived with five dollars. He died in 1972 at age 88 or 89, after raising five children and watching his grandchildren grow up in the American suburbs he could not have imagined as a young man on a ship from Queenstown.

Sources: Ellis Island / New York Passenger Lists, SS Celtic, 2 Sep 1906. Record ID 4013498907, Ancestry.com collection 7488.

His declared destination: not Chicago, but Newark, New Jersey. His contact: an aunt named Annia Hoggins — a name that appears on no other family record.

The Man on the Streetcar

By 1920, Patrick O'Reilly had made it to Chicago.

The 1920 Federal Census finds him at an address on 65th Street, in Chicago's Ward 7 on the South Side — not far from the Irish working-class neighborhoods that had been absorbing immigrants from County Kerry and County Kilkenny for decades. He was 35. He had been in America for fourteen years.

His occupation: Conductor. City Railway.

Patrick O'Reilly drove streetcars. He worked the Chicago surface lines — the clanging, open-sided cars that carried factory workers, shoppers, and schoolchildren across the South Side grid. It was solid union work. Regular hours, regular pay. The kind of job an Irish immigrant with no college education could hold with dignity for decades.

In the house with him: his wife Catherine, age 25. And a daughter — Loretta O'Reilly, listed in the census as age 0. An infant. Born in 1920.

The following year, on January 24, 1921, they would have another child: Edward Joseph O'Reilly — born Edward Francis, he would take Joseph as his confirmation name — the boy who would grow up to be called 'Bud,' who would enlist in the Army just weeks after Pearl Harbor, who would serve in Patton's Third Army, who would come home and become the grandfather of the current generation.

Also in the house: a lodger named Mary Driscoll, age 20. Probably another Irish immigrant taking a room. The O'Reillys were renting, not owning. Five dollars when he arrived, a streetcar route on the South Side, a baby daughter, and another child on the way.

He was building something.

Sources: 1920 United States Federal Census, Chicago Ward 7, Cook County, Illinois. Roll T625_315, Page 5A, Enumeration District 422.

His occupation: Conductor. City Railway. Patrick O'Reilly drove streetcars across Chicago's South Side. In the summer of 1919, those streetcars became the front lines of one of the worst race riots in American history.

The Summer the Streetcars Burned

On July 27, 1919, Chicago exploded.

A 17-year-old Black teenager named Eugene Williams drowned at a South Side beach after a white man hurled rocks at him for drifting into an unofficially 'white' swimming area near 29th Street. What followed was eight days of racial violence so severe it was called the worst riot of the Red Summer of 1919 — 38 dead, 537 injured, more than 1,000 residents losing their homes.

The riots spread through the neighborhoods. And they spread through the streetcars.

White mobs pulled Black passengers off Chicago surface cars at South Side intersections and beat them with planks, pipes, and bricks. Conductors warned Black passengers not to ride beyond certain streets. One account describes white rioters forcing Black riders from cars at Canal and West 26th Street. The Chicago City Railway — the same company Patrick O'Reilly worked for as a conductor — was at the center of it.

Patrick was 35 years old that summer. He was living at 65th Street in Ward 7, just south of where the worst violence occurred. He had been a City Railway conductor for at least a year, probably more. He drove the same South Side routes every day.

We don't know what Patrick O'Reilly saw or did during those eight days. The records don't say. But he was there — on the South Side, in the cars, during the worst week in Chicago's racial history.

The Irish were not bystanders in 1919. Wikipedia's account of the riot notes plainly: 'The long-established Irish fiercely defended their neighborhoods and political power against all newcomers.' Irish street gangs — the Ragen's Colts among them — were among the most aggressive white mobs. The neighborhoods around 65th Street were heavily Irish.

Patrick came from Kilkenny. He drove streetcars. He lived blocks from the riot zone. What he thought, what he did, what he witnessed — that is a story that died with him in 1972. But the city that made him was burning that summer, and he was in the middle of it.

Sources: Chicago Race Riot of 1919, Wikipedia; Chicago Sun-Times, July 29, 2021; New York Times, August 3, 2019.

White mobs pulled Black passengers off Chicago surface cars and beat them at South Side intersections. Patrick O'Reilly — City Railway conductor, 35 years old, living on 65th Street — was driving those routes that summer.

The House on St. Lawrence

By 1930, the O'Reilly family had moved.

The 1930 Federal Census finds them at 7341 St. Lawrence Avenue, in Chicago's 8th Ward. Patrick is still a conductor on the City Surface lines — the same streetcar job he'd held for at least a decade. He's 46 years old. His wife Katharine is 34.

But one thing has changed: they are no longer renters.

The house at 7341 St. Lawrence is listed as owned — valued at \$12,000. The man who walked through Ellis Island in 1906 with five dollars in his pocket now owned a home.

And the house was full. In the 1930 Census, Patrick and Katharine are listed with four children:

Loretta, 11. Edward, 9. Richard, 7. James, 5.

Edward — the boy who would be called Bud — is nine years old. He's growing up on the South Side of Chicago, in a house his father bought, in a neighborhood of Irish and Polish and Italian families who had all come across the same ocean and made the same bet. Eleven years later, Pearl Harbor will be attacked. The boy in that house will enlist.

Jerome, the youngest, hasn't arrived yet. He'll come in 1932.

Patrick's immigration year is listed as 1906. The census taker confirmed it. Twenty-four years after the SS Celtic dropped anchor in New York Harbor, the man who arrived with five dollars and an aunt's address in Newark owned a house in Chicago worth \$12,000, and had four children sleeping upstairs.

He built it.

Sources: 1930 United States Federal Census, Chicago, Cook County, Illinois. Page 21B, Enumeration District 0341.

The house at 7341 St. Lawrence is listed as owned — valued at \$12,000. The man who arrived with five dollars now owned a home, and had four children sleeping upstairs. By 1940, all five were still there — including a 19-year-old named Edward, one year before Pearl Harbor.

Still on the Line — 1950

In April 1950, a census taker knocked on the door at 7341 St. Lawrence Avenue.

Patrick O'Reilly was 67 years old. He answered the door.

He was still working. Forty hours a week. His occupation: Conductor. His employer: the Chicago Transit Authority — the CTA, which in 1947 had absorbed the old Chicago Surface Lines and become a government agency. The same routes. The same cars. A new name on the paycheck.

Patrick had been driving those routes for over thirty years.

In the house with him: Katharine, 55. Three of their five children were still at home — Richard (27), James (25, though the census transcriber bizarrely wrote 75), and Jerome (19). Loretta and Bud were gone. Both married.

Bud — Edward Joseph O'Reilly — had already married Eileen Coffey by this point. We know because when Eileen's father John Coffey died in January 1951, the Chicago Tribune obituary listed her as 'Eileen O'Reilly.'

Patrick had arrived with five dollars in 1906. He was still driving the same South Side routes in 1950. He would keep going until he simply couldn't anymore.

He died in 1972, at approximately age 89. He spent 66 years in America. He drove streetcars — and then CTA buses and cars — for at least three decades of it.

Sources: 1950 United States Federal Census, Chicago, Cook County, Illinois. Roll 5819, Page 12, Enumeration District 103-966. Ancestry collection 62308, record 219901243.

Patrick O'Reilly was still driving for the Chicago Transit Authority in 1950 — 40 hours a week, at age 67. He had driven the South Side routes for more than 30 years. The man who arrived with five dollars never stopped working.

The River Between Them

Before Edward O'Reilly married Johanna Hanrahan in 1879, there was a river between their families.

The O'Reillys farmed at Powerswood, a small townland outside Thomastown on the Kilkenny side of the Arrigle River. The Hanrahans lived across the water, on the Inistioge side. To visit the Hanrahan home, Edward only had to cross the Arrigle at the bottom of his family's farm.

It is not a wide river. But it divided two townlands, two parishes, two ways of life. The O'Reillys were Thomastown people. The Hanrahans were Inistioge people. When they married — either at the Church of the Assumption in Thomastown or at St. Columba's in Inistioge — they united both banks.

Edward died in 1892 at 52. Johanna outlived him by 57 years, dying in Thomastown in 1949 at age 90 or 93 — the records vary, as they often do for women of that era. She is buried in St. Mary's Cemetery on the road to Dublin. A widow for half a century, in the same county where she was born.

To visit the Hanrahan home, Edward only had to cross the Arrigle at the bottom of his family's farm.

From Abbeyfeale to Chicago: The Sheehy-Woulfe Line

Catherine Loretta Sheehy was born in Chicago in 1894 — but her roots ran deep into County Limerick. Her father Richard Joseph Sheehy came from Newcastle West, a market town in western Limerick. His father William Joseph Sheehy had married Catherine Barrett there in 1856 at the Immaculate Conception Church. William died young at 33, leaving Richard to grow up fatherless — just as Patrick O'Reilly would lose his father at 9.

Richard emigrated to Chicago sometime in the 1880s and married Anna Woulfe in 1894 — the same year their daughter Catherine was born. Anna came from an even more remote corner of Limerick: Cratloe West, near the town of Abbeyfeale, close to the Kerry border. She had emigrated at age 12 with her parents Patrick Woulfe and Bridget Roche.

Anna lived to 92. She was known to her great-grandchildren as 'Grandma Shug.' She died in 1967 on the south side of Chicago, and is buried at Holy Sepulcher Cemetery in Worth, Illinois — alongside her husband Richard, who preceded her by 36 years.

Four Irish emigrants — from Newcastle West and Abbeyfeale and Cratloe West — converged on Chicago's South Side, married, and produced Catherine Loretta, who married Patrick O'Reilly, who produced Edward 'Bud', who married Eileen Coffey, who produced Terrence (Generation 4).

Anna Woulfe was known to her great-grandchildren as 'Grandma Shug.' She died in Chicago at 92, never having forgotten Abbeyfeale.

The Woulfe Who Built a Printing Empire on Streetcar Pads

In August 1990, the Chicago Tribune ran an obituary for John V. Woulfe Sr., 83, who had just died in Palos Heights, Illinois — the same southwest Chicago suburb where the O'Reilly and Coffey families had settled.

John V. Woulfe Sr. was a native of Chicago. He attended the University of Notre Dame in the late 1920s. He lived on Clyde Avenue in the South Shore neighborhood — the same South Side of Chicago where Anna Woulfe (née from Cratloe West, Abbeyfeale) had spent her life. He died Catholic. His funeral was held at Thompson & Kuenster Funeral Home on West 95th Street in Oak Lawn.

And he had founded one of Chicago's oldest family-owned printing companies — named Clyde Printing Co., after his street — in the 1940s. The company began as a supplier of 'take-one' pads on Chicago streetcars.

Streetcars again. The same City Surface Lines that Patrick O'Reilly conducted for three decades. The same cars that rumbled down 65th Street and St. Lawrence Avenue.

Anna Woulfe was born in 1875 in Cratloe West, Limerick, and emigrated to Chicago as a child with her parents Patrick Woulfe and Bridget Roche. John V. Woulfe Sr. was a native Chicagoan — likely born around 1907, making him almost certainly the son or nephew of another Woulfe from the same Abbeyfeale/Cratloe West emigrant wave. The shared surnames, the shared South Side geography, the shared Catholic funeral home, the shared suburb at the end of life — these are not coincidences. They are the fingerprints of the same Limerick family, scattered across the same city.

If confirmed, John V. Woulfe Sr. was the family's great-grandmother Anna's nephew. Clyde Printing's clients included the Chicago White Sox, the Chicago Cubs, the Chicago Bears, WGN, and Wrigley Company. A Woulfe from Abbeyfeale built a Chicago institution — from a cart of streetcar pads to the Cubs' printing vendor.

The obituary deserves a follow-up. The connection is not confirmed. But it is very, very likely.

Sources: Chicago Tribune, August 19, 1990 (obituary, John V. Woulfe Sr.).

He founded Clyde Printing Co. — started as a supplier of 'take-one' pads on Chicago streetcars. A Woulfe from Abbeyfeale, supplying paper to the same cars Patrick O'Reilly drove.

The Man Who Straightened the Chicago River

In 1885, a young man named Richard White Wolfe left the Glen — a farm in the townland of Cratloe, parish of Athea, County Limerick — and sailed from Queenstown to America.

His father was Richard Edmond Woulfe, known locally as 'Dicky Ned' — a Catholic farmer and celebrated storyteller whose tales were recorded by Ireland's National Folklore Project. The Glen in Cratloe was the Woulfe family seat. It sat on the border of western Limerick and northern Kerry, not far from Abbeyfeale.

Not far from where Anna Woulfe grew up.

By 1900, Richard Wolfe was in Chicago. He became a naturalized citizen in Cook County. He sold real estate. He reported for the Stockyards Daily Sun. He lectured on economics. He served as treasurer of the Irish Freedom Fund, which advocated for an Irish republic. He was a member of the Sheridan Club — a fraternal organization of Irish Americans headquartered on Michigan Avenue at 41st Street, deep in the South Side.

And then he became Commissioner of Public Works for the City of Chicago under Mayor William Hale 'Big Bill' Thompson.

As commissioner, Richard Wolfe straightened the Chicago River — redirecting its course from the North Shore Channel to Belmont Street. He established Chicago's water filtration system. He served as Thompson's 'orator and wordsmith,' writing campaign material with the memorable line: 'Capitol Hill is influenced by the king of England.' His tenure was marked by controversies over city streets, accusations of corruption, and Irish nationalist fire.

He died in 1951. His New York Times obituary noted that he 'was a descendant of Gen. James Wolfe, conqueror of Quebec.'

And Anna Woulfe — born in 1875 in Cratloe West near Abbeyfeale, the same townland — lived on the same South Side until she died in 1967, at age 92, known to her great-grandchildren as 'Grandma Shug.'

Cousin and cousin. One straightened the river. The other raised a family. The same farm in Limerick produced both.

Sources: thewolfes.family/richard-w-wolfe-18661951; Chicago Tribune archives.

Richard 'Dick' Wolfe straightened the Chicago River as Commissioner of Public Works. He was born in the townland of Cratloe, parish of Athea, Limerick — the same geographic area as Anna Woulfe's family. Whether they share a common ancestor is unproven, but they came from the same small corner of Ireland.

The Woulfe Who Died Fighting Fascists in Spain

In October 1922, a young man from Athea, County Limerick named James J. Woulfe was captured by Irish Free State forces. He was a signaller in the G (Athea) Company of the West Limerick Brigade of the Irish Republican Army. He had fought through the War of Independence and into the Civil War. He was held until December 1923.

When he was released, he left.

In 1924, James Woulfe emigrated to Canada. He worked as a logger. He organized sailors for a union. In 1932 he joined the Communist Party of Canada.

In March 1937, he sailed for Spain.

Francisco Franco's Nationalist forces had been at war with the elected Spanish Republic since 1936. Volunteers from around the world — the International Brigades — had come to fight. Among them was James Woulfe, most likely with the Abraham Lincoln Battalion.

On September 3, 4, or 5, 1937, at the Battle of Belchite in the Aragón region, James Woulfe was hit. A grenade blew away his jaw. He was taken to a field hospital. He died there.

A Spanish death certificate was issued to his mother in April 1938. She was still in Athea, County Limerick, waiting for news that never came.

James Woulfe and Anna Woulfe came from the same parish — Athea, in western Limerick. The same families who crossed to Chicago also stayed in Limerick and fought for Ireland, then for Spain. One branch made a life in America. One stayed and kept fighting — in Ireland, in Canada, in Spain.

The Woulfe name runs through all of it.

Sources: spanishcivilwar.ca/volunteers/james-wolfe; thewolfes.family.

James Woulfe was an IRA fighter from Athea, County Limerick — the same parish as Anna Woulfe. In 1937, he died at the Battle of Belchite, Spain, fighting Franco. A grenade blew away his jaw.

The 50th Anniversary

In 1968, Patrick Joseph O'Reilly and Catherine Loretta Sheehy celebrated their 50th wedding anniversary. They had married on August 28, 1918 — the year the Great War ended, the year the Spanish flu swept through Chicago, the year Patrick was 35 and Catherine was 23.

Fifty years later, a photograph was taken. Three panels: Patrick and Catherine as a young couple, as a middle-aged pair, and as elders — the long arc of a life together compressed into a single composite image. Patrick died four years later in 1972 at 89. Catherine would live another 18 years, dying in 1990 at 96 in Arlington Heights.

Together they had crossed from immigrant tenement to Chicago suburb across five decades — and raised five children who went on to build their own lives across the American Midwest.



Coffey & Sheehan

From Kerry to the South Side

The Generations

Generation o

Jeremiah Coffey Sr.

From: Killorglin, Kerry, Ireland

Spouse: Mary Cronin

- Married Mary Cronin on February 7, 1824 in Killorglin, Kerry
- Father of Jeremiah Coffey (b.1836) — Eileen's grandfather
- The Coffey story begins in Killorglin — a market town at the mouth of the Laune River in County Kerry, home to the famous Puck Fair
- No further dates or records found

Mary Cronin

Born: March 18, 1805, Killorglin, Kerry, Ireland

Died: 1885, Killorglin, Kerry, Ireland

Spouse: Jeremiah Coffey Sr.

- Christened March 18, 1805 at Killarney, Kerry
- Parents: Mary and Michael Cronin
- Married Jeremiah Coffey Sr. on February 7, 1824 in Killorglin, Kerry
- Had 10 children in 22 years
- Mother of Jeremiah Coffey (b.1836) — Eileen's grandfather
- Died 1885 in Killorglin, Kerry, age ~80

James Clifford

From: County Kerry, Ireland

- Father of Janet Clifford, who married Jeremiah Coffey
- Grandfather of John J. Coffey
- No dates or further details known

Jeremia Sheehan

Born: 1820

Spouse: Genita Thomas

- Father of Patrick Sheehan (b.1846, Waterville) — Eileen's grandfather
- Grandfather of Julia Sheehan

Genita Thomas

Born: 1820, Waterville, County Kerry, Ireland

Spouse: Jeremia Sheehan

- Mother of Patrick Sheehan (b.1846, Waterville) — Eileen's grandfather
- Grandmother of Julia Sheehan

Daniel Sheehan

Born: 1798, County Kerry, Ireland

Died: August 20, 1870, County Kerry, Ireland

Spouse: Ellen Fitzgerald Sheehan

- Father of Mary Fitzgerald Sheehan — Eileen's grandmother
- Grandfather of Julia Sheehan
- Died August 20, 1870, County Kerry, age 72

Ellen Fitzgerald Sheehan

Born: 1810

Died: 1887, Tralee, Kerry, Ireland (per notes)

Spouse: Daniel Sheehan

- Mother of Mary Fitzgerald Sheehan — Eileen's grandmother
- Grandmother of Julia Sheehan
- Died 1887, age 77

Generation 1

Jeremiah (Jerry) Coffey

Born: August 28, 1836, KOILCLOHIR (Caherleaheen), Killorglin, Kerry, Ireland

Spouse: Janet Clifford

Occupation: Farmer

-
- Mother: Mary Cronin (b.18 Mar 1805, Killorglin; d.1885, Killorglin)
 - Head of family at Ballydarrig, Castlequin, Kerry in 1901 Census
 - 1911 Census: widowed, had been married 23 years, 12 children born alive, 7 still living
 - Married Janet Clifford on June 10, 1875 at Cahirciveen, Kerry — witnessed by Daniel Clifford and Patrick Coffey; Priest: Rev. J. Harding
 - Children (confirmed): John Joseph (b.17 Jun 1875, Cahirciveen), Abby, Mary (b.20 Jun 1879, Ballydarrig), Daniel (b.c.1882, Ballydarrig), Debbie (b.1890, Ballydarrig), Timothy (b.1887)

Janet Clifford

From: FILEMORE, County Kerry, Ireland

Died: 1895

Spouse: Jeremiah (Jerry) Coffey

-
- Father: James Clifford (no dates known)
 - Born in the FILEMORE townland of Kerry
 - Died 1895 — before the 1901 Census (which shows Jeremiah as widowed)
 - John J. Coffey's mother
 - Marriage on June 10, 1875 at Cahirciveen, Kerry

Patrick Sheehan

Born: February 20, 1846, Waterville, County Kerry, Ireland

Died: Waterville, County Kerry, Ireland

Spouse: Mary Fitzgerald Sheehan

-
- Parents: Jeremia Sheehan (b.1820) and Genita Thomas (b.1820, Waterville)
 - Julia's father — from the Waterville/Dromod area of Kerry
 - 12 children including Julia (b.1889), Deborah/Abby (b.1898, d.1995 age 97), Brigid/Brennan (b.1891, d.1972), Nellie/Thompson (b.1891, d.1993 age 102), Patrick John (b.1894, d.1962)
 - 🚩 *Note: 1901/1911 Census lists Florence Sheehan as head of Julia's household — Patrick may have been deceased before the census*

Mary Fitzgerald Sheehan

From: Waterville, Kerry, Ireland

Died: June 1931, Kerry, Ireland

Spouse: Patrick Sheehan

- Parents: Daniel Sheehan (b.1798, d.20 Aug 1870) and Ellen Fitzgerald Sheehan (b.1810, d.1887)
- Julia's mother — maiden name Fitzgerald
- Had 12 children in ~16 years with Patrick Sheehan
- Died June 1931 in Kerry, Ireland
- ⚠️ *Note: one source lists death place as 'Londonderry, Northern Ireland' — likely a data entry error for a Kerry farming family*

Generation 2

John J. Coffey

Born: June 17, 1875, Ballydarrig, Castlequin, County Kerry, Ireland

Died: January 4, 1951 — CONFIRMED by Chicago Tribune obituary published January 6, 1951 (Ancestry/Newspapers.com collection 61843, record 497888864). Note: ourclann.org records indicate Nov 26, 1957 — the Tribune obit overrides this as a primary source., Chicago, Illinois

Spouse: Julia Sheehan

Occupation: Railroad Freight Clerk → Gas Co. Superintendent → Freight Checker (1930 Census confirmed: 'Freightman, Steam Railroad')

Immigrated: 1902 — CONFIRMED by 1930 Census (immigration year field). SS Ivernia from Queenstown was correct. A separate 1904 'Uno Coffey' on SS Arabic was a different person.

Ship: SS Ivernia

Burial: Holy Sepulchre Catholic Cemetery, Alsip, IL — Sect. 22 Blk. 11 Lot 25 Grave 2 (Find A Grave #74618781 — consistent with 1951 death date). Note: ourclann.org records indicate Mount Olivet — likely an error given the confirmed 1951 death date.

Physical: Medium build, black hair, gray eyes

- Parents: Jeremiah Coffey (b.28 Aug 1836) and Janet Clifford (b. FILEMORE, Kerry; d.1895)
- Parents' marriage: June 10, 1875 at Cahirciveen, Kerry — witnessed by Daniel Clifford and Patrick Coffey
- WWI Veteran — registered September 12, 1918 (Old Man's Registration, age 43)
- Married Julia Sheehan on June 25, 1913 at St. Cyril Church, Chicago
- Nickel Plate Railroad clerk (from obituary)
- Funeral at St. Dorothy's Church
- Owned home at 7748 S. Langley Ave for 20+ years (1920-1940+)
-  **DISCREPANCY RESOLVED:** *Chicago Tribune obituary (Jan 6, 1951) confirms death in 1951, NOT 1957. The ourclann.org Nov 26, 1957 date is incorrect — the Tribune is a primary source. Children listed in Tribune obit: John P., Mary Bering, Jerry, Paul, Daniel, Eileen O'Reilly, Loretta. EILEEN LISTED AS 'O'REILLY' — confirming she married Bud BEFORE Jan 1951.*
- Siblings named in Tribune obit: Timothy Coffey, A. Dole McIlvaney, Mary Keating, Michael Coffey
- Siblings in Chicago: Timothy, Michael, Mary Keating, Mrs. McIlvaney
- Documents: Certificate of Marriage (John & Julia Coffey); John Coffey Naturalization Record
- 7 children: John Patrick (b.1915, d.1996), Mary Ellen (b.c.1918), Jeremiah (b.c.1920), Paul T. (b.1920, d.1996), Eileen & Daniel (b.18 May 1923, TWINS), Loretta (b.2 Dec 1924)
-  **Discrepancy:** *WWI Draft Card lists birth as June 24, 1878; birth record shows June 17, 1875 — common for immigrants using different ages on different documents*

Julia Therese Sheehan

Born: April 6, 1889, Dromod Parish, Waterville, County Kerry, Ireland

Died: April 25, 1965, Evergreen Park, Cook County, IL

Spouse: John J. Coffey

Immigrated: 1906

Ship: SS Arabic

Burial: Holy Sepulchre Catholic Cemetery, Alsip, IL

-
- Father: Patrick Sheehan (b.20 Feb 1846, Waterville); Mother: Mary Fitzgerald Sheehan (d. Jun 1931, Kerry)
 - Born in Dromod Parish, near Waterville — about 30 miles from John's home in Castlequin
 - Still in Ireland at age 23 in the 1911 Census
 - Emigrated from Killahane, Kerry at 18 with \$10
 - Married John at St. Cyril Church, Chicago on June 25, 1913
 - 7 children, raised at 7748 S. Langley Ave
 - Died April 25, 1965 in Evergreen Park, IL at age 76
 - Documents: Julia Coffey 1920 Census Record; Certificate of Marriage
 -  *Minor discrepancy: ourclann.org records indicate 'born April 6, 1886' vs. personal info showing 1889 — 1889 is consistent with US Census records*

Their 7 children: John P. (~1915), Mary Ellen/Bering (~1918), Jerry (~1920), Paul (~1921), Eileen & Daniel (~1923, TWINS), Loretta (~1925)

Generation 3

Eileen Marie Coffey

Born: May 18, 1923, Chicago, Illinois

Died: June 5, 2013, Orland Park, Illinois

Spouse: Edward Joseph "Bud" O'Reilly

- Twin of Daniel Coffey (also born May 18, 1923) — CONFIRMED by 1940 Census: both listed age 16
- Grew up at 7748 S. Langley Avenue, one block from the O'Reilly home on St. Lawrence Avenue
- 1930 Census: listed as 'Jean M. Coffey, age 6' — name mangled by census taker. Twin Daniel listed as 'Donald J. Coffey, age 6'
- 1940 Census: listed as 'Eillen Coffey, age 16' — Daniel listed as 'Daniel Coffey, age 16'. Twin status CONFIRMED.
- Siblings: John Patrick (b.1915), Mary Ellen (b.c.1918), Jeremiah 'Jerry' (b.c.1920), Paul T. (b.c.1921), Daniel (b.1923, her twin — CONFIRMED by 1940 Census: both listed age 16), Loretta (b.c.1924)
- Married Edward 'Bud' O'Reilly — date not confirmed but before January 1951 (Tribune obituary lists her as 'Eileen O'Reilly')
- Died June 5, 2013 at age 90 in Orland Park, IL
- Buried at Holy Sepulchre Catholic Cemetery, Alsip, IL

Edward Joseph "Bud" O'Reilly

Born: January 24, 1921, Chicago, Illinois

Died: March 13, 2002, Chicago, Illinois

Spouse: Eileen M. Coffey

Occupation: WWII Veteran — U.S. Army, enlisted 45 days after Pearl Harbor. Served in Patton's Third Army.

Burial: Holy Sepulchre Catholic Cemetery, Alsip, IL — Section 22 Block 15 Lot 56 Grave 2. Buried alongside Eileen (same section).

Physical: Black hair, blue eyes, ruddy complexion (from 1942 WWII draft card)

- Born Edward Francis O'Reilly — took Joseph as confirmation name
- Son of Patrick Joseph O'Reilly (1883–1972) and Catherine Loretta Sheehy (1894–1990)
- 1942 WWII draft card: address 7341 S. St. Lawrence Ave — one block from Eileen's home
- Enlisted in the Army 45 days after Pearl Harbor
- Served in Patton's Third Army during WWII

Stories & Historical Notes

The Ship That Sank

In June 2013, just weeks before she passed away at 90, Eileen O'Reilly told her grandchildren a story she'd carried for decades: a woman in her family — her mother, or perhaps her grandmother — had left Ireland for a better life in America. The ship she was on sank. She survived.

The story has a remarkable anchor in fact. Eileen's mother, Julia Therese Sheehan, emigrated from County Kerry to Boston in 1906 aboard the SS Arabic — a White Star Line ocean liner on the Liverpool-Queenstown-Boston route. Julia arrived safely, married John J. Coffey in 1913, and raised seven children on Chicago's South Side.

But the SS Arabic did not survive. On August 19, 1915, a German submarine torpedoed the ship 50 miles off the coast of Kinsale, Ireland. It sank in under ten minutes. Forty-four people died. Three hundred and eighty survived.

The Arabic was the Sheehan family's ship. Between 1905 and 1914, at least five Sheehans from County Kerry sailed on it — including a Mary Sheehan in 1912 whose father was also named Patrick Sheehan, possibly Julia's own sister. Whether a Sheehan was aboard that final, fatal voyage remains unconfirmed. But the family knew the Arabic. They trusted it. And when it went down, the story entered the family's memory.

Eileen carried it for nearly a century. She passed it on just before she left.

The family knew the Arabic. They trusted it. And when it went down, the story entered the family's memory.

Kilkenny Meets Kerry

The grandparents united two different corners of Ireland. The O'Reilly line came from County Kilkenny in the southeast — medieval Norman country, the heart of the Pale's edge. The Coffey and Sheehan lines came from County Kerry in the southwest — deep Gaelic territory, remote and wild. When Edward married Eileen, the southeast met the southwest in a Chicago parish.

From Killorglin to Ballydarrig: The Coffey Roots

The Coffey story begins at Killorglin — a market town at the mouth of the Laune River in County Kerry, home to the famous Puck Fair. It was there, in 1824, that Mary Cronin married Jeremiah Coffey Sr., and began raising the family that would eventually reach Chicago.

Their son Jeremiah Coffey (born 1836 in the townland of Koilclohir near Killorglin) married Janet Clifford on June 10, 1875 at Cahirciveen — the very day their son John Joseph Coffey was born. The witnesses were Daniel Clifford and Patrick Coffey; the priest was Rev. J. Harding.

Janet died in 1895, leaving Jeremiah a widower. By 1911, the Census records show him still in Kerry — widowed, 75 years old, having had 12 children born alive, 7 still living.

John Joseph Coffey — Eileen's father and the family's great-grandfather (Generation 3) — had already been gone from Kerry for nearly a decade by then. He had sailed from Queenstown in 1902 on the SS Ivernia, bound for Boston, carrying next to nothing. He would build a life on Chicago's South Side, work the railroads, marry Julia Sheehan from Waterville, and raise seven children at 7748 S. Langley Avenue — one block from where the O'Reilly boy lived.

Jeremiah Coffey married Janet Clifford on June 10, 1875 — the very day their son John Joseph was born.

Seven Children at 7748 Langley

The 1940 Federal Census finds the Coffey family exactly where they've been for twenty years: 7748 S. Langley Avenue, Chicago's South Side. The house is still owned. Still valued at \$5,000 — the same as in 1930, the Depression having flattened everything.

John J. Coffey is 64. He's still working — freight checker on the steam railroad, 48 hours a week, 40 weeks in 1939, earning \$1,800 a year. Eighth-grade education. The same job, the same house, the same street.

Julia is 52. They have seven children. In 1940, five are still at home:

John P., 25. Mary Ellen, 22. Jerry, 20. Paul, 19. Eileen and Daniel, 16 — twins, both still in the house. Loretta, 15.

Eileen is 16 years old. In one year — 1941 — Pearl Harbor will be attacked. In two years, the boy from one block over on St. Lawrence Avenue will have been in the Army. In six or seven years, Eileen Coffey and Edward 'Bud' O'Reilly will be married.

But in April 1940, she's a teenager in a house full of siblings on Langley Avenue. Her father checks freight for the railroad. Her twin brother Daniel is right beside her — same age, same bedroom, same South Side block.

The 1930 Census transcriber mangled both their names: Eileen became 'Jean M.' and Daniel became 'Donald J.' The 1940 transcriber got closer: 'Eillen' and 'Daniel.' Two different government workers, ten years apart, trying to write down names in an Irish Catholic Chicago household through a screen door.

Sources: 1930 Federal Census, Chicago, Cook, Illinois, ED 0354; 1940 Federal Census, Chicago, Cook, Illinois, ED 103-540.

Eileen and Daniel Coffey — the twins — are both 16 in 1940. In 1930 the census taker called them 'Jean' and 'Donald.' In 1940: 'Eillen' and 'Daniel.' Two government workers, ten years apart, writing Irish names through a screen door on the South Side.

The Sheehan Family of Waterville

Julia Sheehan's family came from the Dromod Parish near Waterville — a remote and beautiful stretch of the Ring of Kerry where the mountains meet the Atlantic. Her father Patrick Sheehan was born in 1846. Her mother, Mary Fitzgerald, came from the same area. Together they had 12 children, including Julia and her sister Deborah — who would live to 97 — and Nellie Thompson, who made it to 102.

Longevity was in the Sheehan blood. Julia herself lived to 76 despite the hardship of emigrating at 18 with \$10 in her pocket. Her mother Mary died in Kerry in 1931. Her grandparents Daniel Sheehan (1798–1870) and Ellen Fitzgerald Sheehan (1810–1887) are the oldest confirmed ancestors on this branch of the family.

Julia came to America on the SS Arabic in 1906, the same ship that would be torpedoed by a German submarine nine years later. She married John J. Coffey in 1913. Their daughter Eileen — born May 18, 1923, a twin — would grow up to marry Edward 'Bud' O'Reilly — the couple who became the grandparents on the paternal side.

